2.8 Routing and configuration on Next.js

Compared to our previous Express.js setup, Next.js provides us with a significant advantage with its unique approach to routing using the *app router*. The configuration file is also important, as it helps customize your app's behavior.

2.8.1 File-based routing

Next.js uses a powerful concept called *file-based routing*. This means the very structure of your project folders defines the application's URL routes. Each folder within the src/app directory represents a route segment, and the presence of a page.js file within that folder makes it a publicly accessible page. Figure 2.9 shows an example structure and the corresponding URLs.

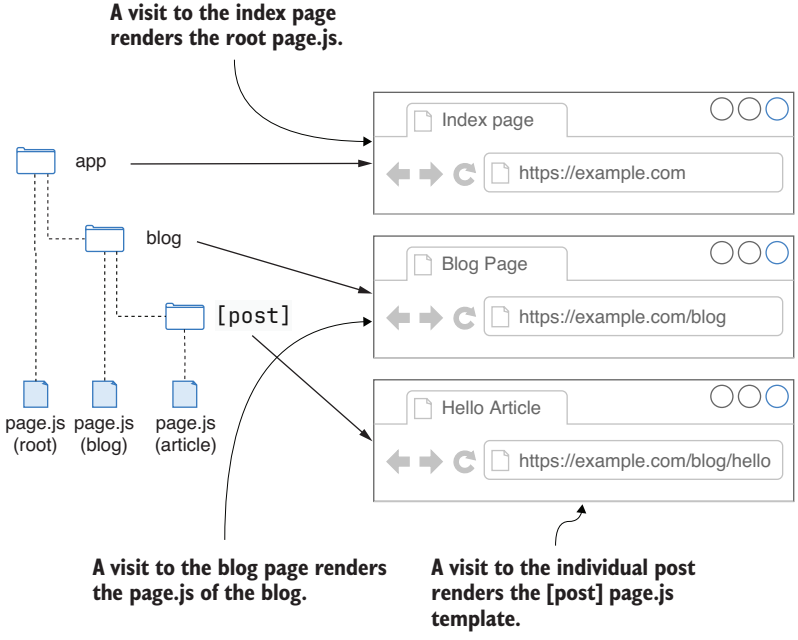


Figure 2.9 File-based routing in Next.js. The root page.js in the app corresponds to the index page (/). The blog page.js in the blog folder corresponds to the blog path (/blog). Finally, the route segment that corresponds to individual articles (wrapped in brackets [ ]) corresponds to the blog post path (/blog/hello).

The app folder acts as a route segment for chat functionality. The presence of a page.js file inside the chat folder creates a publicly accessible page at the URL /. This pattern applies similarly to the blog folder. Here, the page.js file defines a page accessible at /blog. Essentially, the folder structure mirrors the URL segments, and a page.js file within a folder translates to a publicly accessible page at that specific URL.